

Robert B. Boeder
Department of History
Michigan State University

During the past eighty years great numbers of Malawians have emigrated from predominantly rural country to search for work throughout East, Central, and Southern Africa. The 1962/67 Malawi Ministry of Labor Report stated that between 1962, 544,000 men, 70,000 women, and 70,000 juveniles had gone to Southern Rhodesia; between 1953 and 1967, approximately 360,000 men went to South Africa; during those years roughly 69,000 men, 25,000 women, and 30,000 juveniles had the journey to neighboring Zambia. Smaller numbers have traveled to Mozambique, and Tanzania, but the total number of Malawians affected by emigration during a century runs into the millions. This mass migration has been one of the key elements in twentieth century Malawian history, vitally influencing social, economic, cultural, and cultural developments in the country. Early accounts of the exodus of the suffering in rural areas resulting from the absence of so many men. We not denying this basic fact, this paper suggests that the disastrous effects have been exaggerated initially, that communal institutions absorbed some of the social shock, and that after the mid-1930's interterritorial labor agreements agreed the worst economic consequences of emigration.

Correspondence between the Nyasaland administration and the Foreign and Commonwealth Offices reveals that clergymen have been among the most consistent voices drawing attention to the evil social and economic repercussions of labor migration. In 1900, fifty-six missionaries joined seventy other Europeans--mainly teachers and businessmen--in signing a British Central Africa Chamber of Agriculture Commerce petition protesting emigration from the Protectorate (F.O.2/669). The petition, and the Elmslies of Livingstonia all endorsed the document which complained that village life in Nyasaland was deteriorating as a result of immoral practices acquired by migrants in South Africa and Southern Rhodesia. The petition declared that it was essential to the financial welfare of the country that indigenous labor supply be retained so that European-owned estates could have abundant supply of cheap manpower essential for profitable operations.

This paper was presented initially to Professor B. Pachai's history seminar at the University of Malawi and has benefited substantially from comments and improvements suggested by students and staff, particularly Dr. M. Schoffeleers. My research has been financed partially by a grant from the International Studies Center of Michigan University. Any errors are my responsibility.